

Job Rejection Letter Templates

Eight letters from screening to background check, plus a candidate communication log

After application screening

Candidate	
Role	
Stage	After application screening
Date	
Sender	

Dear [Name], Thank you for applying for the [role] position at [Company]. We received a strong response and have decided not to progress your application to interview on this occasion. We appreciate the time you took to apply and encourage you to look at future openings that match your experience. Best regards, [Name], [Title]

After a first interview

Candidate	
Role	
Stage	After a first interview
Date	
Sender	

Dear [Name], Thank you for meeting [interviewer] on [date] to discuss the [role] position. We enjoyed the conversation and were impressed by [one specific, genuine point]. After careful consideration we have decided to move forward with other candidates whose experience is closer to [the specific requirement]. This was a difficult decision. We would be glad to consider you for future roles and will keep your details on file for [12 months] unless you ask us not to. Thank you again for your interest in [Company].

After a final interview

Candidate	
Role	
Stage	After a final interview
Date	
Sender	

Dear [Name], Thank you for the time and preparation you put into the interview process for [role], including the [presentation / task] on [date]. We have decided to offer the position to another candidate. The decision came down to [honest, specific factor, e.g. depth of experience in X], not to any shortcoming in how you presented yourself. [If offering feedback: I would be happy to share more detailed feedback by phone if that would be useful.] We were genuinely impressed and would like to stay in touch about [type of role] openings. Thank you again.

Internal candidate

Candidate	
Role	
Stage	Internal candidate
Date	
Sender	

Dear [Name], Thank you for applying for the [role] position and for the interview on [date]. We have decided to appoint another candidate. I want to be direct about the reasons, because you are a valued member of the team: [specific, developmental reasons]. [Manager] and I would like to put a development plan in place so that you are positioned for the next opportunity, and I would like to discuss that with you on [date]. Thank you for putting yourself forward.

Role withdrawn or put on hold

Candidate	
Role	
Stage	Role withdrawn or put on hold
Date	
Sender	

Dear [Name], Thank you for your application for the [role] position. Since advertising the role, [the position has been placed on hold / the role has been withdrawn] because of [brief reason, e.g. a change in business priorities]. This is not a reflection on your application. If the role reopens in the next [period], we will contact you first. Thank you for your interest and your patience.

Overqualified or salary mismatch

Candidate	
Role	
Stage	Overqualified or salary mismatch
Date	
Sender	

Dear [Name], Thank you for interviewing for the [role] position. We have decided not to proceed because we believe the role would not make full use of your experience, and the compensation we can offer is below what your background would warrant. We would rather be direct about that than waste your time. We would welcome your application for [more senior role / future openings] and will let you know when something suitable opens.

Candidate rejected after a background check

Candidate	
Role	
Stage	Candidate rejected after a background check

Date	
Sender	

Dear [Name], Following your conditional offer for the [role] position, we have completed the background check. Based on information in the report, we are considering not proceeding with your employment. A copy of the report and a summary of your rights under the Fair Credit Reporting Act are enclosed. You have [5 business days] to dispute the accuracy of the report with [agency] or to provide additional information before a final decision is made. [Second letter after the waiting period, if proceeding with the decision: We have made the final decision not to proceed. The decision was based in whole or in part on the report provided by [agency, contact details], which did not make the decision and cannot explain it. You have the right to obtain a free copy of the report within 60 days and to dispute its accuracy with the agency.]

Keeping a strong candidate warm

Candidate	
Role	
Stage	Keeping a strong candidate warm
Date	
Sender	

Dear [Name], Thank you for interviewing for [role]. We appointed another candidate for this role, but we want to be specific: we would like to hire you, and we expect [a similar role / a role in team X] to open in [timeframe]. With your permission, I will contact you directly when it does, and I would be glad to introduce you to [person] in the meantime. Thank you for your interest in [Company].